

When the Bottom Fell Out

The Great Depression & the New Deal · 1929–1941 | Standards US.39, US.40, US.41, US.42, US.43, US.44

Name _____

- Archive (J. Troop)
- Spark
- Navigator
- Notetaker

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

In 1929 the richest country on earth fell into its worst economic disaster, and one in four workers lost their jobs through no fault of their own. When the bottom falls out for millions of people, whose job is it to catch them — themselves, their neighbors, or their government? The answer America argued out in the 1930s still shapes your life today.

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories.

buying on margin	Dust Bowl
Hooverville	rugged individualism
the New Deal	Relief, Recovery, Reform
TVA	court-packing

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Your read & evidence
1	Analyze the interlocking causes of the Great Depression — margin buying, bank failures, overproduction, and the Smoot-Hawley Tariff. Notice: You buy something with money you don't have, betting you'll pay it back when your investment goes up. Everybody's doing it, so it feels safe.... Debrief: Explain how a stock market crash turned into a decade-long Depression. Identify at least three causes and show how one caused or worsened another.	
2	Analyze the human-caused ecological disaster of the Dust Bowl and the forced migration and discrimination it produced. Notice: Imagine the sky itself turning against you. A wall of black dust two thousand feet high, rolling across the horizon at sixty miles an hour... Debrief: Explain why the Dust Bowl is called a 'human-caused' disaster, not just a natural one. Then describe what happened to families like Opal's, and how <i>The Grapes of Wrath</i> changed public understanding.	
3	Analyze the human toll of the Great Depression — mass unemployment, Hoovervilles, hunger, and the unequal way it fell. Notice: One in four. Picture your class, and cross out every fourth person's job — gone. Now imagine there's no unemployment check, no food stamps, no... Debrief: Describe three ways the Depression harmed ordinary Americans, and explain why it fell harder on some groups than others. Why might a photograph like 'Migrant Mother' change minds when statistics don't?	
4	Analyze Hoover's response to the Depression — 'rugged individualism,' the RFC, and the Bonus Army — and why it failed politically. Notice: You're the president. A quarter of the country is out of work, people are starving, and everyone is looking at you. You genuinely believe that if... Debrief: Explain Hoover's philosophy of 'rugged individualism' and how it shaped his response to the Depression. Then explain how the Bonus Army episode helped end his presidency. Was his philosophy wrong, or just wrong for this crisis? Defend your view.	
5	Analyze FDR's New Deal through the 'Three Rs' — Relief, Recovery, and Reform — and the lasting institutions it created. Notice: A minimum wage. A limit on your work week. Insurance so your grandparents don't starve when they're old. Insurance so your family's bank savings... Debrief: Explain the 'Three Rs' of the New Deal with one program for each. Then explain one way the New Deal fell short of helping all Americans equally. Which New Deal program do you think mattered most, and why?	
6	Analyze the Tennessee Valley Authority as the New Deal's most dramatic regional transformation — flood control, electrification, and its impact on... Notice: Flip a switch. Light. You've done it ten thousand times without a thought. Now imagine you're seventeen and you have never once done it — every... Debrief: Explain what the TVA did and why it mattered so much to the rural South. Then explain one benefit and one cost or controversy of a government building and owning something like the TVA.	
7	Analyze the opposition to the New Deal, the Supreme Court's rejection of key programs, and FDR's failed court-packing plan. Notice: What happens when a president does so much, so fast, that people start asking whether he's rescuing democracy or endangering it? The New Deal... Debrief: Explain why the New Deal faced opposition, how the Supreme Court responded, and why FDR's court-packing plan failed. What does this fight show about the balance of power in American government?	

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 5 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **hoover-business-sound-1929**

1. Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?
2. Spark's question: *Four days later the market suffered the worst crash in its history, and within four years more than 9,000 banks had failed. Ask: why would the...*
3. What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Toward ↗ or away ↘?	Why — your evidence
1929	The stock market crash		
1932	The Bonus Army is driven from Washington		
1933	The New Deal begins		
1933	The TVA lights up the Tennessee Valley		
1935	Social Security is enacted		
1937	The court-packing plan fails		

B Debrief & Closing Argument

This unit is where America rewrites the deal between a person and their government. For 150 years the answer to 'who catches you when you fall'...

Closing question: The New Deal permanently expanded what the federal government does for ordinary people — and Americans have argued about whether that was rescue or overreach ever since. Using at least two programs from this unit, argue whether the New Deal moved the country closer to its founding promise or further from it. Then name one thing it left unfinished. Cite the unit — there's no answer key.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now: